

Humble leadership and employee creative performance in China: the roles of boundary spanning behavior and traditionality

Humble
leadership and
creative
performance

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper examined the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior and the moderating effects of traditionality linking humble leadership and employee creative performance from the perspective of Social Exchange Theory (SET) to reveal the behavioral mechanism and boundary condition regarding the influence of humble leadership on creative performance.

Design/methodology/approach – A sample of 276 employees and the supervisors from 8 companies in China was taken using two-wave data.

Findings – The results indicated that humble leadership was positively related to employee creative performance, and boundary spanning behavior partially mediated the relationship between humble leadership and employee creative performance. Traditionality strengthens the mediation process when traditionality is high.

Practical implications – These findings provide several theoretical and practical implications for the domains of humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior. For example, human resource (HR) departments can recruit leaders with high humility and cultivate team leaders through systematic training programs about self-awareness, openness and self-transcendence; team leaders should encourage employees to participate in boundary spanning activities and hiring managers select employees with high traditionality to synergize with leader humility.

Originality/value – Based on the SET, this paper explored the behavioral mechanism between humble leadership and creative performance and enriched the prior research, which is from the cognitive or emotional view, and further answered the question “what are the employees’ behavioral responses when they confront the humble leadership”.

Keywords Humble leadership, Creative performance, Boundary spanning behavior, Traditionality

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

With the increasing turbulence of the environment, individual creative performance is crucial to organizational success (Wang *et al.*, 2018a). Thus, how to improve the creative performance of employees is a more important issue for managers. They attempt various methods to enhance the creative performance of employees. For example, human resource (HR) managers investigate the personality (Li *et al.*, 2020), work values (Ren *et al.*, 2021) and emotional intelligence (Darvishmotevali *et al.*, 2018) of employees in the screening and hiring stage to lay the foundation for obtaining high creative performance. In the process of work, the HR department will also provide performance rewards for employees who have achieved high creative performance (Zhang *et al.*, 2014). Researchers also have devoted much attention to exploring the antecedents of employee creative performance, such as high-performance work practices (Safavi and Karatepe, 2018) and Guanxi human resource management (HRM) practices



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(Yang and Yang, 2020) and they found that leadership is a key factor that cannot be ignored (Zhang and Bartol, 2010). Different from other related leadership such as authentic leadership and servant leadership (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022), humble leadership as a bottom-up leadership style has attracted extensive attention from theoretical and practical fields in recent years (Ou *et al.*, 2018; Owens and Hekman, 2012). Previous research has made significant progress in understanding how humble leadership fosters employees' creativity or innovative behavior (Wang *et al.*, 2018a). The majority of studies focus on employees' cognitions, emotions and attitudes (e.g. Hu *et al.*, 2018; Owens and Hekman, 2012; Zhou and Wu, 2018). However, there is limited research on the behavioral mechanism that links humble leadership and employee creative performance. We still know little about how employees respond to humble leadership and what role these behaviors play in the relationship between humble leadership and creative performance, leaving us with an incomplete picture of how humble leadership affects creative performance. Research on individual behaviors strongly complements the literature on person and context predictors of creative performance (De Stobbeleir *et al.*, 2011). In addition, by studying the behavioral mechanism, managers and employees can know which specific behavior is more beneficial or not beneficial to the improvement of employees' creative performance (Li *et al.*, 2020). Some scholars call on future research to strengthen the exploration of the behavioral mechanism of enhancing employee creative performance (De Stobbeleir *et al.*, 2011; Li *et al.*, 2020). Therefore, it is necessary to explore the behavioral mechanism between humble leadership and creative performance.

Given the increasing network and complexity of human activities, boundary spanning activities are inevitable (Zhang and Li, 2020), and boundary spanners can exchange information, knowledge and resources with outsiders, which are the important driver of creative performance (Tortoriello and Krackhardt, 2010). Moreover, creative performance is the behavioral result of combining different ideas and knowledge in the process of social interaction (Perry-Smith and Shalley, 2003). Boundary spanning behavior refers to individual behavior aimed at establishing a linkage or engagement with external actors to support the team in attaining performance goals (Choi, 2002; Marrone, 2010). It is a specific behavior of individuals' interaction with the outside (Marrone *et al.*, 2007). As a result, boundary spanning behavior is helpful to enhance individual creative performance. Based on the above statement and social exchange theory (SET) (Blau, 1964), we argue that boundary spanning behavior is likely to be a behavioral mechanism linking the relationship between humble leadership and creative performance. Specifically, when humble leaders recognize their own mistakes and limitations, highlight others' strengths and contributions, and see employees as teachers (Owens and Hekman, 2012), employees may feel a high trust and psychological empowerment (Jeung and Yoon, 2016; Nielsen *et al.*, 2010). According to SET (Blau, 1964), when a leader provides trust, resources and empowerment, employees will reciprocate them with positive behaviors like boundary spanning behavior, which helps to improve team performance and employees' creative performance (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Furthermore, humble leaders encourage leader-employee roles in reverse (Owens and Hekman, 2012), hoping that employees can take on a leader's role. Employees' boundary spanning behavior is likely to impact how their teammates perceive their leadership (Marrone *et al.*, 2007). Boundary spanners gain some information, knowledge and resources from external parties, increasing the possibility of improvements in individual creative performance (Liu *et al.*, 2018; Marrone *et al.*, 2007). To our knowledge, few studies have explored the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior between humble leadership and employee creative performance. Thus, this research investigates whether employees' boundary spanning behavior can mediate the relationship between humble leadership and creative performance.

Furthermore, humble leadership is not always effective (Owens and Hekman, 2012). The literature shows that the relationship between leadership and employee behavior may

differ as a function of individual and contextual factors (Hu *et al.*, 2018; Yang *et al.*, 2017). However, prior research paid less attention to the role of employee-related moderators in the humble leadership process (Jeung and Yoon, 2016). Gawronski and Bodenhausen (2006) pointed out that individuals' preference for humble leadership varies with the cultural values of eastern and western societies. In China, traditionality is considered one of the most crucial cultural value variables (Farh *et al.*, 2007). As stated above, boundary spanning behavior may be a behavior that individuals exhibit to reciprocate their humble leaders. Employee traditionality provides an important background condition for an individual's choice of exchange preference and then subtly influences an individual's social exchange process (Zhu and Xie, 2018). That is, the different level of employee traditionality may affect the exchange between individuals and leaders and, in turn, influence the linkage between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior. However, recent studies have examined the role of traditionality in moderating the relationship between leadership and employee outcomes (Li *et al.*, 2014, 2017). It is still unknown whether employee traditionality interacts with humble leadership to influence boundary spanning behavior.

The current study contributes to the existing literature in the following three aspects. First, this study emphasizes behavioral mechanisms that link humble leadership and creative performance rather than focusing on cognitive and emotional mechanisms. Based on SET (Blau, 1964), we test the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior and attempt to answer what behaviors employees do in response to humble leadership and what role such behavior plays in the above relationship. Thus, the application of SET in the field of humble leadership and employee boundary spanning behavior is expanded. Second, this study is the response to recent calls for identifying the employee-based contingency factors (i.e. cultural values) in the humble leadership process (Jeung and Yoon, 2016; Owens *et al.*, 2013). We investigate the moderating role of traditionality in the relationship between humble leadership and employee creative performance. Finally, this study contributes to the humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior literature in the Chinese context, extending our understanding of these topics to a non-Western context. The theoretical model of this paper is shown in Figure 1.

Literature review and hypotheses

Humble leadership has received extensive attention from researchers in the past 10 years. Prior research has adopted qualitative and quantitative methods to define humble leadership or leader humility. For example, Oc *et al.* (2015) found 9 dimensions of humble leadership through qualitative interviews. Ou *et al.* (2014) used empirical research to define CEO humility through 6 dimensions, three of the dimensions are from Owens *et al.* (2013) and added 3 dimensions (low self-focus, self-transcendent pursuit, transcendent self-concept). Among them, Owens and Hekman' (2012) definition of humble leadership and Owen *et al.*'s (2013) measurement scale have been widely recognized (for a review, see Kelemen *et al.*, 2022). Specifically, humble leadership refers to leaders who admit their own mistakes and

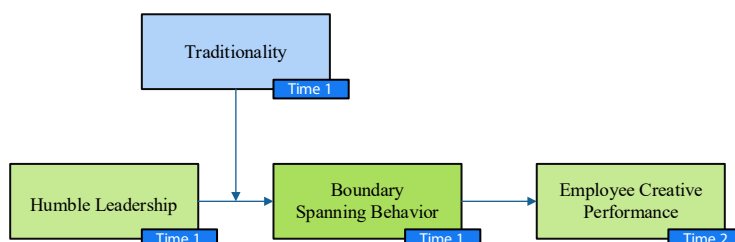


Figure 1.
Theoretical model

limitations, highlight followers' strengths and contributions, and teachability (Owens and Hekman, 2012). Furthermore, humble leadership is unique from other related leadership (Owens and Hekman, 2012), such as authentic leadership, servant leadership and ethical leadership (see Kelemen *et al.*, 2022). Specifically, First, both authentic leadership and humble leadership concentrate on a leader's self-awareness, but humble leadership focuses on followers' strengths and contributions (Owens *et al.*, 2013), whereas authentic leadership aims to keep individuals' behavior consistent with their core values and beliefs (Lemoine *et al.*, 2019). Second, both servant leadership and humble leadership focus on subordinates' development, but humble leadership does not consider the development of subordinates as the ultimate goal. Moreover, humble leadership legitimizes uncertainty, but servant leadership does not. Finally, humble leadership partially overlaps with the dimensions of ethical leadership. For example, humble leadership and ethical leadership both motivate employees, but it does not mean that ethical leadership recognizes followers' strengths (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022). In a word, humble leadership is different from other leadership constructs, the underlying mechanism are distinct.

Previous studies have linked humble leadership to different employees outcomes, such as job satisfaction, engagement (Nielsen *et al.*, 2010), psychological empowerment (Jeung and Yoon, 2016), employee resilience (Zhu *et al.*, 2019), innovation behavior (Zhou and Wu, 2018) and task performance (Wang *et al.*, 2018b), by emphasizing the psychological mechanisms which including core self-evaluation, emotional exhaustion, psychological safety and perceived insider identity (Walters and Diab, 2016; Wang *et al.*, 2018b; Zhou and Wu, 2018; Zhu *et al.*, 2019). Although humble leadership can lead to a variety of behavioral outcomes for employees, such as creativity, proactive behavior and voice (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022), little is known about the behavioral mechanism of the effect of humble leadership. To fill the research gap, this study examines the behavioral mechanism (i.e. boundary spanning behavior) between humble leadership and creative performance.

Humble leadership and employee creative performance

Creative performance can be defined as producing novel or valuable ideas, products and procedures to benefit a group or organization (Janssen and Van Yperen, 2004; Madjar *et al.*, 2002). Individual creative performance is considered to be partially the result of their context stimulation (Perry-smith and Shalley, 2003). Leadership is an important contextual factor, and its effect on creative performance cannot be ignored (Zhang and Bartol, 2010). Extensive research has indicated that employee creative performance can be influenced by leadership, including empowering leadership, authentic leadership and transformational leadership (Hughes *et al.*, 2018; Koh *et al.*, 2019), but the influence of humble leadership on creative performance is still unexplored (Wang *et al.*, 2017). A recent review of research distinguishes humble leadership from other leader behaviors (see Kelemen *et al.*, 2022). We argue that humble leadership may be positively related to employee creative performance. First, humble leaders show openness to new ideas, encourage employees to learn from failure and take responsibility for employees' mistakes. These behaviors are conducive to the formation of a supportive organizational climate. For example, empowering atmosphere or learning climate (Ou *et al.*, 2014; Zhu *et al.*, 2019), may foster employees' creative performance through intrinsic motivation (Hon, 2012) or knowledge sharing (Carmeli *et al.*, 2013; Xue *et al.*, 2011). Meanwhile, creative activities are often suffused with uncertainties and challenges; humble leadership legitimates uncertainty, improving employees' psychological freedom and facilitating creativity and innovation (Zhou and Wu, 2018).

Second, humble leaders recognize their flaws and limitations, value followers' strengths and contributions, and seek to be taught by employees. These can improve employees' perceptions of trust, respect and support (Jeung and Yoon, 2016; Zhou and Wu, 2018), and

employees will then reciprocate leaders with positive attitudes, behaviors and performance, according to SET (Blau, 1964). Based on this, we speculate that humble leadership may influence employee creative performance positively. Additionally, humble leaders who appreciate employees' strengths and expertise are more likely to respect employees' creative efforts (Zhou and Wu, 2018). Employees may demonstrate more creative engagement when they think that their efforts are valued by leaders, which leads to creative performance (Richard *et al.*, 2019; Zhang and Bartol, 2010). Furthermore, humble leaders have a relational identity orientation; they are more concerned with the welfare and needs of their subordinates (Nielsen *et al.*, 2010). Thus, employees are more likely to develop high-quality leader-member exchange (LMX) with leaders (Owens and Hekman, 2012). Most research has shown a positive relationship between LMX and employee creative performance (Van Dyne *et al.*, 2002; Volmer *et al.*, 2012).

Finally, humble leadership can be considered a resource (Ali *et al.*, 2020). Conservation of resource theory (Hobfoll, 1989) suggests that people strive to conserve and protect their valued resources. When people have enough resources, they will invest the present resources to gain more other resources. We believe that humble leadership may bring various resources to employees, such as trust, empowerment, self-efficacy and psychological capital (Ali *et al.*, 2020; Jeung and Yoon, 2016; Nielsen *et al.*, 2010; Rego *et al.*, 2019). Then, employees may invest the above resources to gain other resources (i.e. creative performance) to defend against the external threat or future resource loss. A prior study has shown that leader humility can decrease cognitive burdens, flourish cognitive resources for creativity (Owens and Hekman, 2012) and ultimately improve employees' creative performance. Therefore, we propose hypothesis 1 as:

H1. Humble leadership is positively related to employee creative performance.

The mediating role of employee boundary spanning behavior

As mentioned above, boundary spanning behavior is defined as the behavior of employees establishing relationships with external actors to support the team in attaining work unit goals. It mainly includes ambassador activities, task-coordinator activities and scout activities (Ancona and Caldwell, 1992), which aim to represent the team in a positive way to external entities to obtain resources and expertise and manage relationships across work teams (Marrone *et al.*, 2022). Boundary spanning behavior is a multi-level construct (Joshi *et al.*, 2009; Marrone, 2010), such as member, team and network. However, past research mainly focuses on team-level analysis, the studies on the antecedents and outcomes of individual boundary spanning behavior are still not enough (Marrone, 2010). Several studies explored the influence factors of employee boundary spanning behavior, such as boundary spanning role, boundary spanning self-efficacy (Marrone *et al.*, 2007) and supportive coaching (Marrone *et al.*, 2022), as well as some outcomes, such as task performance (Liu *et al.*, 2018), role overload (Marrone *et al.*, 2007) and enhanced reputation and influence (Marrone, 2010). Although prior research mainly explained the influence mechanism of humble leadership through social information processing theory, conservation of resources theory and social learning theory (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022), considering SET is a key theory in explaining how humble leaders trigger employees' positive behavioral responses (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022), and creative performance may be a result of individuals exchange knowledge, resources and information with others (Perry-smith and Shalley, 2003). Thus, we use the SET as a holistic theoretical framework to explain the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior.

We argue that humble leadership may impact employee boundary spanning behavior positively. As stated above, humble leaders appreciate others' strengths and contributions and pay much attention to employees' needs and growth (Owens and Hekman, 2012).

From the perspective of social exchange, the employee may reciprocate leaders in various ways, such as positive attitudes and behaviors, when employees are valued and supported by leaders (Blau, 1964). Thus, employees may show boundary spanning behavior to gain external resources, information and support for their leaders or teams. Moreover, humble leaders encourage leader-member role reversal (Owens and Hekman, 2012); leaders hope that employees can undertake a leader's role and responsibility. Team members often perceive employees who cross boundaries as highly influential leaders (Marrone, 2010). Recently, Liu *et al.* (2018) demonstrated that individual boundary spanning behavior is positively related to informal leadership emergence. As a result, the boundary spanning behavior is in line with the expectations of humble leaders on the roles and responsibilities of employees, which stimulates employees to exhibit more boundary spanning behaviors.

Furthermore, the literature indicates that motivations and resources are two important determinants for individual boundary spanning behavior (Joshi *et al.*, 2009; Marrone, 2010). Whereas motivations influence employees' "want to do", and resources affect employees' "can do". Traits of humble leadership, such as appreciating employees' strengths, publicizing employees' merits and helping employees to affirm their process of development (Owens and Hekman, 2012), help to improve the perception of work value and meaning, enhance employees' intrinsic motivation (Pierce *et al.*, 2009), thus motivating employees' boundary spanning behavior. Additionally, employees may make mistakes or even fail in boundary spanning activities. Still, humble leaders encourage employees to learn and grow by trial-and-error rather than criticize or punish them (Owens and Hekman, 2012). These leader behaviors can provide psychological resources for employees, such as psychological freedom and self-efficacy (Owens and Hekman, 2012; Zhu *et al.*, 2019); therefore, employees may have more resources to perform boundary spanning behavior. In a word, a humble leader can promote boundary spanning behavior by increasing the motivations and resources of employees.

Although there is little research exploring the linkage between boundary spanning behavior and creative performance, indirect evidence of the positive relationship between the two constructs can be found in some studies. For example, the literature showed that boundary spanning behavior can help an individual to gain specific knowledge and information, support from external parties, enhance one's interpersonal influence and understand the environmental opportunities and threats (Marrone, 2010). Such behavior may be beneficial to generating new ideas or methods and then enhancing individual creative performance (Pan *et al.*, 2018). Liu *et al.* (2018) demonstrated that boundary spanning behavior could foster informal leader emergence, fostering boundary spanner creativity. Similar research also found that informal leadership is positively related to individual performance (Zhang *et al.*, 2012). That is because individuals assume emergent leader roles; they are prone to take on increasing responsibilities and have more motivation to make better use of the knowledge and information from others, thus helping them achieve high performance. Following this logic, we believe that boundary spanning behavior may impact individual creative performance positively.

In summary, we have hypothesized a positive relationship between humble leadership and creative performance (Hypothesis 1). Further, proposed humble leadership will lead to boundary spanning behavior, which will result in higher employee creative performance by adopting a social exchange perspective. Accordingly, we expect that:

- H2. Boundary spanning behavior mediates the relationship between humble leadership and employee creative performance.

The moderating role of traditionality

Chinese traditionality is indigenous to China, Farh *et al.* (1997) introduced it into the field of organizational management. It refers to how an individual endorsement of hierarchical

role relationships (as defined by Confucian) social ethics includes subject to authority, respect for their ancestors, filial piety, self-protection and male superiority (Farh *et al.*, 2007). Different traditionalists display different attitudes and behaviors when facing the same leader (Yao *et al.*, 2020). High traditionalists are governed by social roles and they are more likely to unconditionally obedient to their leaders, expect nothing in return and fulfill the prescribed role obligations to maintain interpersonal harmony (Li *et al.*, 2014; Yang *et al.*, 1989), while low traditionalists follow the rules of inducement-contribution (Farh *et al.*, 1997). Thus, high traditional employees are more prone to be attracted to leaders with Confucian virtues (Li *et al.*, 2014) and accept the leadership (Yao *et al.*, 2020). Previous research demonstrated that Chinese traditionality moderates the relationship between leadership and attitude, behavior and performance. For example, Li *et al.* (2014) found that traditionality moderates the positive impact of authentic leadership on perceived leader interactional justice. Liu *et al.* (2013) verified the positive moderating role between perceived ethical leadership and task performance, OCBO [1] and OCBI [2]. The results support their hypotheses. Following these studies, we argue that traditionality moderates the positive effect of humble leadership on boundary spanning behavior.

Humble leadership is rooted in Chinese traditional values (Oc *et al.*, 2015). Those employees who have high traditionality may look forward to humble leaders. Hence, they are likely to be more motivated by humble leaders than low traditionalists. In addition, high traditionalists appreciate leaders' trust, liking and recognition (Li *et al.*, 2014). Humble leaders just appreciate followers' strengths and contributions and seek to be taught by employees, which may send the signal that leaders trust and like their subordinates (Jeung and Yoon, 2016; Li *et al.*, 2014; Nielsen *et al.*, 2010). Thus, compared with low traditionalists, high traditionalists may respond more favorably to their leaders' positive influence, which in turn exerts a more facilitating effect on boundary spanning behavior. An old Chinese saying, "persons who died as confidants" means high traditionalists will display more boundary spanner behaviors to repay their leaders with resources and support from external parties.

Furthermore, high traditionalists pursue external factors (e.g. leaders) to stimulate their behaviors (Liu *et al.*, 2013), thereby paying more attention to humble leadership, which leads to more boundary spanning behavior. Meanwhile, with attention to humble leaders, traditionalists could strengthen the reciprocation to leaders or teams (Liu *et al.*, 2013). Therefore, their boundary spanning behavior may further increase. Taken together, we propose:

- H3. Traditionality moderates the relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior so that the relationship is stronger for employees high in traditionality.

The integrated moderated mediation model

Combined with Hypothesis 2 and 3, we further propose that traditionality moderates the indirect effect of boundary spanning behavior between humble leadership and employee creative performance. High traditionalists are more sensitive and attentive to humble leadership, which in turn leads to boundary spanning behavior, and ultimately enhances employee creative performance. Therefore, we propose an integrated moderated mediation model that the interaction effect of humble leadership and traditionality on creative performance via the boundary spanning behavior. Accordingly, we propose:

- H4. Traditionality moderates the mediation effect of boundary spanning behavior between humble leadership and employee creative performance. The higher traditionality of an employee is, the stronger the relationship between humble leadership and creative performance via boundary spanning behavior.

Methodology

Sample and procedure

According to the suggestions of (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003), to reduce the common method variance caused by the self-report method, this study adopted a two-wave questionnaire survey method to collect data from 8 firms in China, including three banks, three IT firms, one manufacturing firm and one real estate firm. The employees' work covers R&D, operation, and marketing. Before the survey, we communicated with the HR managers to identify and code the employees and supervisors participating in the survey to match the two-wave survey. All participants were informed that the data collection was only for academic purposes, and the overall analysis was carried out without revealing personal information. We surveyed 320 employees to obtain data about humble leadership, boundary spanning behavior, traditionality and demographic variables. Out of 320 questionnaires, 277 were received. Three months later, 277 employees' creative performance was assessed by their 54 team direct supervisors at time 2, with an 86.6% effective response rate. Of the 277 employees, 39.1% were male, the average age was 29.22 years, and the average organizational tenure was 4.98 years. In terms of education, 37.1% had a master's degree and 59.3% had a bachelor's degree.

Measures

All variables were evaluated by a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree) and were translated into Chinese except for traditionality followed a back-translation procedure (Brislin, 1970).

Humble leadership. We measured humble leadership using Owens *et al.* (2013) 9-item scale. A sample was "my supervisor acknowledges when others have more knowledge and skills than him-or herself." Cronbach's in this study is 0.83.

Boundary spanning behavior. We measured boundary spanning behavior using Marrone *et al.* (2007) 4-item scale. A sample was "I persuade outsiders (e.g. faculty, clients) to support our team's decisions." Cronbach's in this study is 0.80.

Employee creative performance. We measured employee creative performance using a 3-item scale following the Madjar *et al.* (2002) method. A sample was "This employee can use existing information and materials to develop new ideas, methods or products that will be useful to the team." Cronbach's in this study is 0.75.

Traditionality. We measure traditionality using a 5-item scale developed by Yang *et al.* (1989). A sample was "The best way to avoid mistakes is to follow elders' instructions." Cronbach's in this study is 0.66.

Control variables. According to previous research (e.g. Carmeli *et al.*, 2013; Liu *et al.*, 2018; Madjar *et al.*, 2002), we controlled for gender (1 = male; 2 = female), age (in years), education (1 = master or doctor degree; 2 = bachelor degree; 3 = junior college; 4 = senior high school or below), organizational tenure (in years), time spent work with direct supervisors (in months) and hierarchical position (1 = rank-and-file employees, 2 = first-line supervisors, 3 = high-level managers) because these variables may influence boundary spanning behavior and employee creative performance.

Results

Because supervisors in our sample evaluated the employee creative performance of multiple employees, observed effects of observations were a possibility (Yang *et al.*, 2017). Following recent research (Ren *et al.*, 2019; Yang *et al.*, 2017), we conducted a one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) with employee creative performance as the dependent variable, $F(54, 277) = 1.08, p = 0.34$, showed no systematic differences in supervisor-rated creative

performance. We also ran a null model with no predictors but employee creative performance as the dependent variable using Hierarchical Linear Modeling 6.08. Results indicated that between-work unit variance in employee creative performance was not significant ($\chi^2 = 56.88$, $df = 53$, $p = 0.33$, $ICC = 0.01$) and less than 5% of the total variance accounted for by work unit membership (Ren *et al.*, 2019). Taken together, these results suggested that even though our data has a nested structure, the individual level of analysis in the current study is appropriate.

Confirmatory factor analysis and common method variance

We applied AMOS 17.0 to conduct confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to test the discriminant vitality of four core constructs. We compared the fit indexes and χ^2 differences among the following four models. The CFA results are presented in Table 1. As Table 1 showed, the goodness fit of four-factor model ($\chi^2 = 78.52$, $df = 29$, CFI = 0.93, NFI = 0.90, RMSEA = 0.08) was better than other alternative models. Thus, the four constructs have a good discriminant vitality and are distinguishable.

Furthermore, followed (Li *et al.*, 2014) research, we compared a model by combining the same source's variables (see Two-factor model in Table 1) with a four-factor model. The two-factor model would fit the data well if the common method variance (CMV) is serious. The results showed the two-factor model was much worse ($\Delta\chi^2 = 229.15$, $p < 0.01$) than the four-factor model. Therefore, the potential CMV is not serious in our research.

Descriptive statistics

Table 2 presents the means, standard deviations and correlations of all variables. As indicated in this table, humble leadership was positively related to employee creative performance ($r = 0.36$, $p < 0.01$) and boundary spanning behavior ($r = 0.23$, $p < 0.01$).

Testing of hypotheses

Hierarchical linear regression was used to examine all hypotheses, the results as shown in Table 3. Hypothesis 1 proposed that humble leadership is positively related to employee creative performance. The results of Model 2 in Table 3 indicated that humble leadership was positively related to employee creative performance ($\beta = 0.40$, $p < 0.001$), hence, hypothesis 1 was supported.

Hypothesis 2 proposed that boundary spanning behavior mediates the relationship between humble leadership and employee creative performance. To test the mediation effect, we performed a four-step procedure based on Baron and Kenny (1986) as follows: (1) after control demographics variables (Model 1), regressing the independent variable (i.e. humble leadership) on the dependent variable (i.e. employee creative performance), the relationship was significant (see Model 2); (2) regressing the independent variable on the mediator (i.e. boundary spanning behavior), humble leadership was positively related to boundary spanning behavior (Model 6, $\beta = 0.25$, $p < 0.001$); (3) regressing mediator on the

Model	χ^2	df	$\Delta\chi^2$	CFI	NFI	RMSEA
Four-factor model: HL, BSB, TRAD, ECP	78.52	29		0.93	0.90	0.08
Three-factor model: HL + BSB, TRAD, ECP	251.36	32	172.84**	0.70	0.68	0.16
Two-factor model: HL + BSB + TRAD, ECP	307.67	34	229.15**	0.63	0.61	0.17
One-factor model: HL + BSB + TRAD + ECP	425.54	35	347.02**	0.47	0.46	0.20

Note(s): ** $p < 0.01$; HL = humble leadership, BSB = boundary spanning behavior, TRAD = traditionality, ECP = employee creative performance

Table 1.
Confirmatory factor
analysis

Table 2.
Descriptive statistics
and correlations

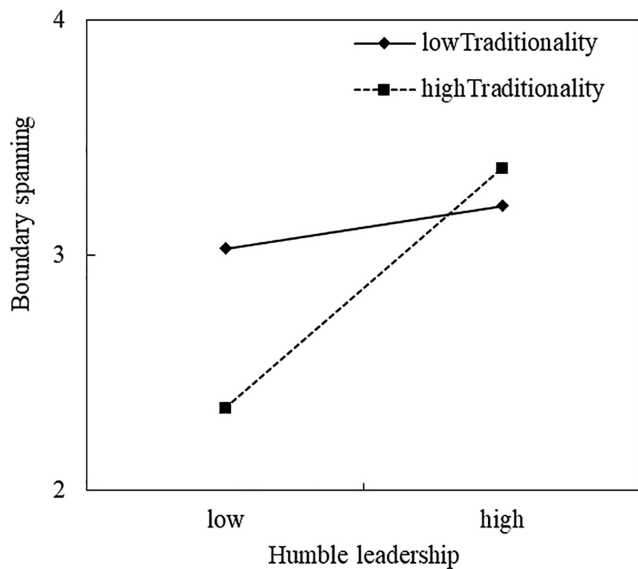
Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Gender	0.61	0.49									
2. Age	29.23	2.91	-0.14 [*]								
3. Education	2.61	0.52	0.10	-0.13 [*]							
4. Organizational tenure	4.98	2.64	-0.11	0.55 ^{**}	0.08						
5. TSWS	3.07	2.81	-0.13 [*]	0.24 ^{**}	-0.13 [*]	0.35 [*]					
6. Hierarchical position	1.49	0.71	-0.14 [*]	0.37 ^{**}	-0.16 [*]	0.31 [*]	0.27 ^{**}				
7. Humble leadership	3.42	0.69	0.09	-0.03	-0.04	-0.10	-0.08	0.05			
8. Boundary spanning behavior	3.93	0.56	0.00	0.04	-0.02	0.02	0.12	0.09	0.23 ^{***}		
9. Traditionality	2.72	0.71	-0.18 ^{**}	0.09	-0.04	0.16 ^{**}	0.16 ^{**}	0.04	0.17 ^{***}	-0.05 ^{***}	
10. Employee creative performance	3.44	0.58	-0.24 ^{**}	0.25 ^{**}	-0.07	0.11	0.17 ^{**}	0.20 ^{**}	0.36 ^{***}	0.24 ^{***}	0.24 ^{***}
Note(s): [*] $p < 0.05$, ^{**} $p < 0.01$; TSWS = time spent work with direct supervisors											

Variable	Employee creative performance				Boundary spanning behavior				Humble leadership and creative performance 203
	Model1	Model2	Model3	Model4	Model5	Model6	Model7	Model8	
<i>Control variables</i>									
Gender	−0.20**	−0.25***	−0.20***	−0.24***	0.03	0.00	−0.02	−0.02	
Age	0.19*	0.17*	0.17*	0.16*	0.04	0.03	0.02	0.05	
Education	−0.05	−0.07	−0.04	−0.07	0.01	0.01	0.00	−0.01	
Organizational tenure	−0.06	−0.01	−0.05	0.00	−0.06	−0.03	0.00	−0.02	
TSWS	0.09	0.11	0.06	0.10	0.12	0.13	0.14	0.14	
Hierarchical position	0.09	0.05	0.09	0.05	0.07	0.05	0.04	0.03	
Independent variable									
Humble leadership (HL)		0.40***		0.37***		0.25***	0.28***	0.30***	
<i>Moderating variable</i>									
Traditionality (TRAD)							−0.13*	−0.13	
Interactive items									
HL × TRAD								0.21***	
<i>Mediating variable</i>									
Boundary spanning behavior			0.23***	0.13*					
R ²	0.10	0.25	0.17	0.27	0.02	0.08	0.09	0.10	
ΔR ²	0.10	0.15	0.06	0.02	0.02	0.06	0.01	0.04	
F	5.70***	13.63***	7.36***	12.87***	0.93	3.10**	3.21**	4.33**	
Note(s): * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$									
Hierarchical regression result									

dependent variable, boundary spanning behavior was also positively related to employee creative performance (Model 3, $\beta = 0.23$, $p < 0.001$); (4) after mediator was entered into the model, regressing the independent variable on dependent variable, the results indicated that humble leadership was still positively related to employee creative performance, but the coefficient for humble leadership decreased from 0.40 (Model 2) to 0.37 (Model 4). It indicated that boundary spanning behavior partially mediated the relationship between humble leadership and employee creative performance. To test the indirect effect, we conducted the mediation test using the SPSS PROCESS (Hayes, 2013) to test the indirect effect. We found that the 95% confidence interval of the indirect effect was [0.01, 0.07], which does not include 0. These results show that the indirect effect of humble leadership on employee creative performance via boundary spanning behavior was significant. Thus, hypothesis 2 was supported.

Hypothesis 3 predicted that traditionality would moderate the relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior. As shown in Model 8, the interaction of humble leadership and traditionality significantly influenced boundary spanning behavior ($\beta = 0.21$, $p < 0.001$); therefore, the Hypothesis was supported. To further examine the moderating role of traditionality, we conducted regression analyses. We plotted the relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior at the mean of traditionality plus and minus one SD based on the Aiken *et al.* (1991) approach. Figure 2 showed that the positive relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior was significant in only high traditionality, simple slope test indicated that the effect

Figure 2.
The moderating role of
traditionality between
humble leadership and
boundary spanning
behavior



was stronger (*simple slope* = 0.51, $p < 0.001$) when traditionality was high than traditionality was low (*simple slope* = 0.09, *n.s.*); hence, [hypothesis 3](#) was supported.

[Hypothesis 4](#) proposed that traditionality moderates the indirect effect of boundary spanning behavior. We applied the SPSS PROCESS ([Hayes, 2013](#)) by following [Preacher et al. \(2007\)](#) methods to test the moderated mediation effect. The results as shown in [Table 4](#). From this table, we found that the indirect effect was stronger when traditionality was high ($\beta = 0.05$, $p < 0.01$) than when traditionality was low ($\beta = 0.02$, *n.s.*), providing support for [Hypothesis 4](#).

Discussion

We used SET to test a model and explained how and when humble leadership positively influences employee creative performance. The results indicated that humble leadership is positively related to employee creative performance, boundary spanning behavior mediates the linkage between humble leadership and employee creative performance, and traditionality moderates the positive relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior. Furthermore, we established an integrated moderated mediation model of the interaction between humble leadership and traditionality on employee creative performance was mediated by boundary spanning behavior.

Theoretical implications

Our study makes several theoretical contributions. First, this study extends previous research by exploring employees' behavior as a mechanism to explain how humble

Table 4.
Moderated mediation
effect

Moderator	Effect	Boot SE	Boot 95% LLCI	Boot 95% ULCI
High Traditionality	0.05	0.02	0.01	0.11
Low Traditionality	0.02	0.01	−0.00	0.05
Index	0.03	0.01	0.01	0.06

leadership links with employee creative performance. To our knowledge, little attention has been paid to examining the behavioral mechanism between humble leadership and creative performance. Our study suggests that humble leadership could motivate employees to display boundary spanning behavior, which may help them gain knowledge, information and resources, thus enhancing their creative performance. Unlike most studies focusing on employees' attitudes, cognition and emotions (Kelemen *et al.*, 2022), our findings provide a new insight for researchers via boundary spanning behavior to understand how humble leadership is related to employee creative performance. In addition, SET again acts as a useful theoretical foundation to link the influence of leadership on employees' responses.

Second, previous research suggested that humble leadership is not always effective and cultural values may influence the expression of leader humility (Owens *et al.*, 2013). We examined the moderating role of traditionality between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior. Our findings supported the idea that the relationship between humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior was stronger when traditionality was high than when traditionality was low. This result is consistent with Liu *et al.* (2013) and Li *et al.* (2014)'s findings that leadership and traditionality influence employees' attitudes and behaviors. Further, our study also echoes the calls for examining the employee-based contingency factors in the humble leadership process (Jeung and Yoon, 2016) and facilitates future research to pay attention to the cultural boundary condition of humble leadership's influences.

Third, our study contributes to previous research by testing how employees respond and adjust their behaviors to meet humble leaders' expectations in the Chinese context. As we know, humility is rooted in Confusion society (Oc *et al.*, 2015), which emphasizes reciprocity and responsibility, that is, "receive a droplet a generosity and repay like a gushing spring" (Chen and Chen, 2004; Li *et al.*, 2014) and "persons who died as confidant". Although boundary spanners may encounter many difficulties, challenges and stresses, humble leadership may evoke the reciprocal ideology and role obligation of employees, promoting boundary spanning behavior. Our findings extend the literature about humble leadership and boundary spanning behavior to Chinese society.

Practical implications

This study also provides some practical implications for organizations. First, our findings indicate that humble leadership can improve employee creative performance. Thus, HR departments need to recruit leaders with high humility that can lead them to display high levels of humble leadership (Morris *et al.*, 2005). Furthermore, some situational questions can be asked to examine the candidate leaders' tendency toward humility. For example, hiring managers can ask a prospective leader to describe in detail the reasons for failures they've experienced, how they handled them, or what they hope to learn from other subordinates. In addition, HR departments can offer systematic leadership training and development programs to teach leaders how to acknowledge their limitations, appreciate subordinates' strengths and keep open to others' views (Ou *et al.*, 2014). Criteria of recruitment and training can be referred to the scale in Owens *et al.* (2013).

Second, the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior suggests that team leaders should encourage employees to participate in boundary spanning activities. For example, organizations create a favorable environment for employees boundary spanning behavior by building channels of communication between them and the outside world, and leaders advocate for members going outside the team or organization to obtain knowledge, information and resources, support and reward individuals who undertake the boundary spanning role and recognize the advantage of boundary spanning behavior (Liu *et al.*, 2018).

Finally, managers should aware that humility is not always effective, it depends on employee traditionality (Li *et al.*, 2014), particularly in China (Liu *et al.*, 2013). Specifically, high

traditionalists respond positively to humble leaders. HR managers can strategically select employees with high traditionality, as a high traditionality synergizes with leader humility to improve employees' boundary spanning behaviors. Moreover, managers should adopt different strategies for the different levels of traditionalists. For high traditionalists, managers should display more humble leadership behaviors and in turn, motivate them to cross boundaries for the benefit of the team. For low traditionalists, managers should highlight reciprocal ideology and role obligation and strengthen the positive cognition of humble leadership.

Limitations and future research

Our research has some limitations. First, although our data was collected from a two-wave survey, the causal conclusion may not be inferred confidently. Future research can design a longitudinal study or experimental study to ascertain the causal relationships. Second, to avoid CMV, we collected data from different sources, but a team leader's assessment of an employee's performance may be impacted by the relationship quality between leader and employee (Li *et al.*, 2014; Liu *et al.*, 2013). Despite widely accepting the leader's rating of employees' behavior and performance in academic research (Li *et al.*, 2014), future research would gather objective performance information or use objective performance measurement methods. Third, other theories can explain the proposed relationship, such as social information processing theory and conservation of resource theory, in addition to SET. Fourth, we emphasized the behavioral mechanism between humble leadership and employee creative performance, but we only examined the mediating role of boundary spanning behavior. Our findings also suggested that other mediators may exist; thus, other behavioral mechanisms deserve to be explored in the future, such as feedback-seeking behavior and individual learning behavior. Finally, we only explored the moderating role of traditionality and other cultural values or individual differences such as collectivism, power distance and the Zhongyong thinking style that deserve further investigation in the future.

Notes

1. OCBO = Organizational citizenship behavior directed toward the organization.
2. OCBI = Organizational citizenship behavior directed toward the individual.

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